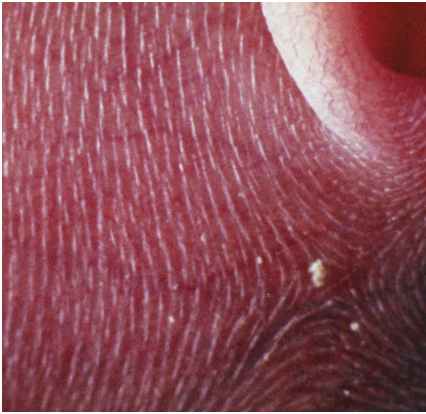




YOU ARE **21 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

127 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This is a close-up of the baby's skin just behind the ear. Every part of the skin's surface has small ridges and hollows in a unique pattern. During this week, the dermal ridges—the deeper layers of skin—start to mature, giving rise to finger- and toe-prints.

“Your baby has been filtering amniotic fluid and storing the waste as a substance called meconium.”

At the end of this week, your baby's anal sphincter muscle is fully functional. This should prevent any small particles of meconium from being passed into the amniotic fluid. Meconium is first produced at 12 weeks. It is the greenish/black first bowel movement that 9 out of 10 newborn babies pass in the first 24 hours. Meconium is formed mainly from cells discarded from the lining of the gut as it lengthens and expands, and the waste of any nutrients that have been absorbed from the swallowed amniotic fluid. It is continuously produced, slowly moving down the gut to enter the large bowel (colon) by 16 weeks. Meconium is sterile since there are no organisms inside the gut and no bowel gas is produced.

YOUR BABY'S HANDS

The unborn baby will move their hand to their mouth and even suck their thumb. Research has shown that the baby may even open their mouth in anticipation.

Anything that the baby's hands encounter is firmly grasped and this grip is strong enough to support all of the baby's body weight.

KEEP TONED

Effective strength training during pregnancy, using free weights or a machine at your gym, will help your body deal with the demands of pregnancy. Being stronger will help you carry the increase in body weight and also help you recover after the baby is born. Having more toned limbs will help you look and feel better, too. Always follow these guidelines when exercising with weights:

- **If you've been doing regular weight training**, continue with your program, but do not increase the weight loads or repetitions.
- **If you're new to using weights**, begin with very light ones and few repetitions and build up slowly. Do not increase the weight load until you are confident that you are able to manage the increase.